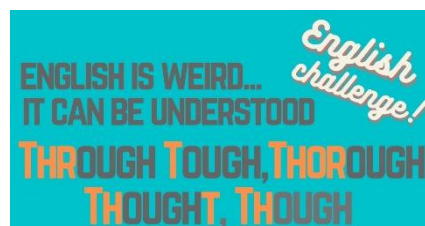


M04: The Sounds of English

Knowing about the differences between English and German sounds is very likely to make your English sound better. Not knowing about them, however, could in the worst case even change the meaning.

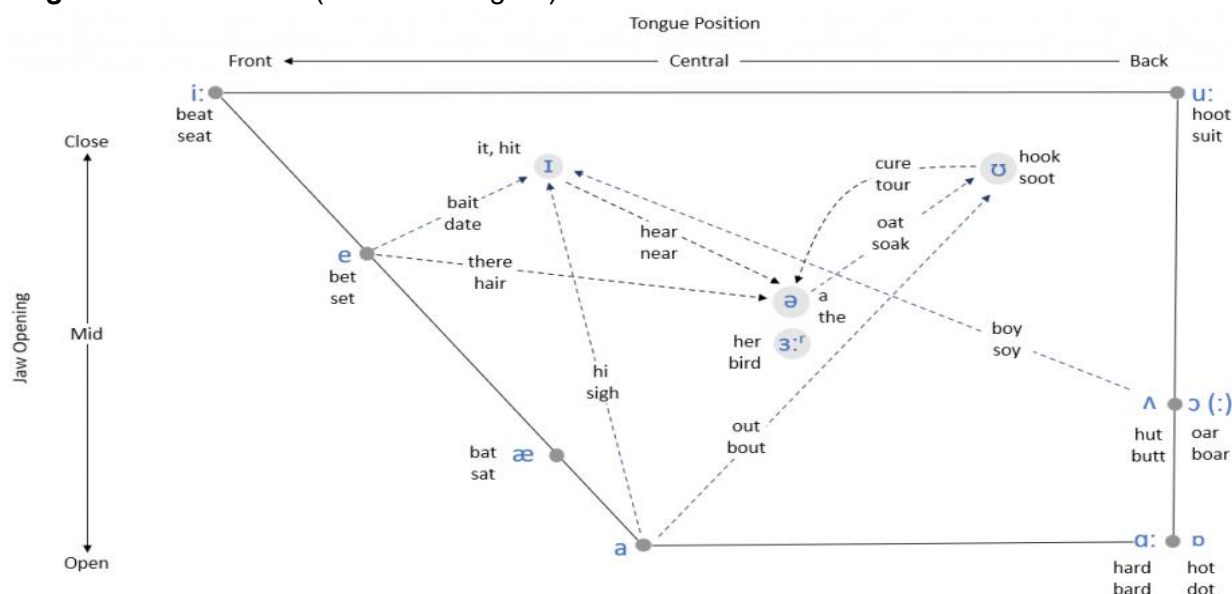


You probably know all the sounds of English, so you only need to learn how they are written in the 'phonetic alphabet' (a system of special symbols). There is one each for consonants and vowels.

English consonant sounds

	Labial (lips)	Dental (teeth)	Alveolar (behind teeth)	Post- alveolar (top of mouth)	Palatal (upper back of mouth)	Velar (back of mouth)	Glottal (throat)
Nasal (nose)	<u>m</u> mouse		<u>n</u> nose			<u>ŋ</u> ring	
Plosive (airflow briefly stopped)	Voicless <u>p</u> pig		<u>t</u> two	<u>tʃ</u> cheap		<u>k</u> card	
	Voiced <u>b</u> big		<u>d</u> do	<u>dʒ</u> jeep		<u>g</u> guard	
Fricative (hissing sound)	voiceless <u>f</u> fan	<u>θ</u> think	<u>s</u> bus	<u>ʃ</u> sheep			<u>h</u> hello
	voiced <u>v</u> van	<u>ð</u> then	<u>z</u> buzz	<u>ʒ</u> vision			
Approximant (between fricative and vowels)			<u>l</u> love, milk	<u>r</u> right	<u>j</u> universe	<u>w</u> water	

English vowel sounds (for British English)



Why Phonetic Alphabets? Letters are not enough

Sounds are written using special symbols called a phonetic alphabet. These are necessary because letters do not conform to sounds – *create*, *China* and *city* all start with the letter *c* but use different sounds: /k/, /tʃ/ and /s/.

Many of these phonetic letters are easy to understand for Germans (m, n, p, b, t, d, k, g, f, v, z, r), some you must learn (ʃ in sheep, ʒ vision, tʃ in beach, dʒ in jeans, /θ/ in thin and /ð/ in then). A few others may be surprising (cf section 'Consonants').

Vowels are a larger problem for learners because there are many small differences to German. Also, because there are only five vowel letters in writing (*a e i o u*), we need more phonetic symbols to describe them all. More on this in the section 'Vowels'.



Phonetic alphabets use special symbols to write sounds. Here, you can find the *nasal* (you use your nose) *ingressive* (you inhale) *velar* (something happens in the back of your mouth) *trill* (a ringing sound).
Be bold, try it out loudly!

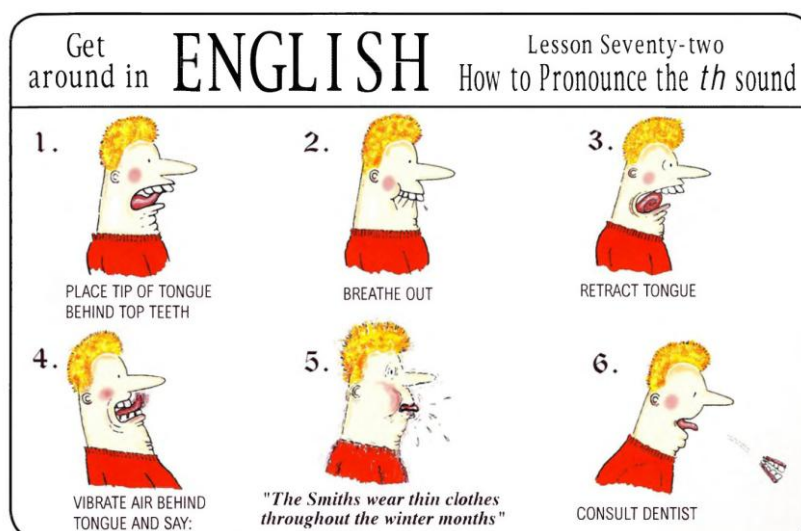
Voiced vs voiceless sounds

Were you confused by the 'voiced' and 'voiceless' rows in the table above?

The difference between the two is whether your vocal folds (*Stimmbänder*) vibrate when you produce a sound. All vowels are voiced – but for most consonants there is a voiceless version which is otherwise identical: *pat* – *bat*, *too* – *do*, *class*¹ – *glass*, *fan* – *van*.

Is a sound voiced or voiceless?

When putting your fingers onto your Adam's Apple, you should feel a vibration when producing voiced sounds (vowels + voiced consonants), but not for voiceless consonants.



¹ Remember that there may be a letter *c*, but the pronunciation is a /k/.

Practicing English Consonants

To master English consonants, you need to be able to pronounce them. Sounds simple enough, but German lacks some consonants of English. In the following tasks, you get the chance to practice some of the more difficult sounds.

Task #1: With a partner, take turns pronouncing a consonant sound from the table on page 1. Check if your partner's pronunciation is correct by clicking on the phonetic symbols in the table. If you do not get it right – or want to sound perfect, use the support box below.

Tricky differences between German and English

Most consonants are unsurprising for German learners of English: m, n, p, b, t, d, k, g, f, v, z, r. But there are some differences in what first seem to be similar sounds:

The sound in *sheep* has less lip rounding than *Schaf* in German. The *ʒ* sound in *vision* is produced in the same way but also voiced (*j* is voiceless), so your vocal folds should vibrate (it should not sound like DE *wischen*). *tʃ* in *beach* and *dʒ* in *jeans* are identical to the first two except for the additional /t/ or /d/. Finally, there are the *th* sounds /θ/ in *thin* and /ð/ in *then*, which learners often replace with the closest German alternative (/d/, /f/, /s/).

A few other sounds have surprising features and differences:

1. /w/ in English is pronounced with rounded lips, tongue not touching the teeth – while in German, the upper teeth touch the lower lip and there is less lip rounding. Compare **EN** *water* vs **DE** *Wette*.

The German /w/ is closer to the English /v/ sound – compare /w/ in *wine* or *while* with /v/ in *vine* or *vile*.

2. There is a clear and dark // in English.
 - Clear // comes before vowels (e.g. *love*) and is like in German.
 - But there is also a dark // which comes after vowels (e.g. *milk*, *cold*) at the beginning of a syllable (so, not in *alight*).
 - For both types, your tongue tip touches your upper teeth, but for the clear //, your tongue's sides want to move upwards while for the dark //, they want to move downwards.

Task #2: Record yourself pronouncing the following pairs of words.² You may work with a partner, correcting each other and aiming for maximum precision. In your recording, say each pair two times.

sheep /ʃi:p/ – Jeep /dʒi:p/ – cheap /tʃi:p/	
vision /'viʒən/ – wischen (DE)	rich /rɪtʃ/ – ridge /rɪdʒ/
fan /fæn/ – van /væn/	leaf /li:f/ – leave /li:v/
milk – cold vs. love – list (clear vs. dark l)	
thin /θɪn/ – this /ðɪs/	thank /θæŋk/ – that /ðæt/
though /ðəʊ/ – dough /dəʊ/	though /ðəʊ/ – so /səʊ/
vet /vet/ – wet /wet/	vile /vaɪl/ – while /waɪl/
ship /ʃɪp/ – chip /tʃɪp/	shop /ʃɒp/ – chop /tʃɒp/
rice /raɪs/ – rise /raɪz/	face /feɪs/ – phase /feɪz/
water /'wɔ:tə/ – Wasser (DE)	wet /wet/ – Wette (DE)

Struggling with final sounds? 'Auslautverhärtung'

Did you have trouble pronouncing pairs such as *rich-ridge*, *leaf-leave*, *rice-rise* and *face-phase*? That is because you had to pronounce voiced consonants at the end of words, which never happens in German (we pronounce *Tag* with a final /k/ not /g/, even if spelt with a g).

This is a problem because you may be misunderstood by others. The best way to improve is practicing to keep word-final **/b, d, g, v, z, ʒ/** sounds voiced in words like *cab*, *bed*, *big*, *love*, *buzz*, *ridge*.

Task #3: The words below will all be difficult due to Auslautverhärtung – you will struggle to pronounce them correctly, so take some time!

Work with a partner and practice these minimal pairs. Record your list when you are ready. Again, read each pair of words two times. Should you find it difficult to produce the sounds, go slowly and exaggerate the sounds.

cab /kæb/ – cap /kæp/	tap /tæp/ – tab /tæb/
bad /bæd/ – bat /bæt/	code /kəʊd/ – coat /kəʊt/
bet /bet/ – bed /bed/	bag /bæg/ – back /bæk/
dog /dɒg/ – dock /dɒk/	have /hæv/ – half /hɑ:f/
belief /bɪ'li:f/ – believe /bɪ'li:v/	vine /vaɪn/ – wine /waɪn/
buzz /bʌz/ – bus /bʌs/	once /wʌns/ – ones /wʌnz/

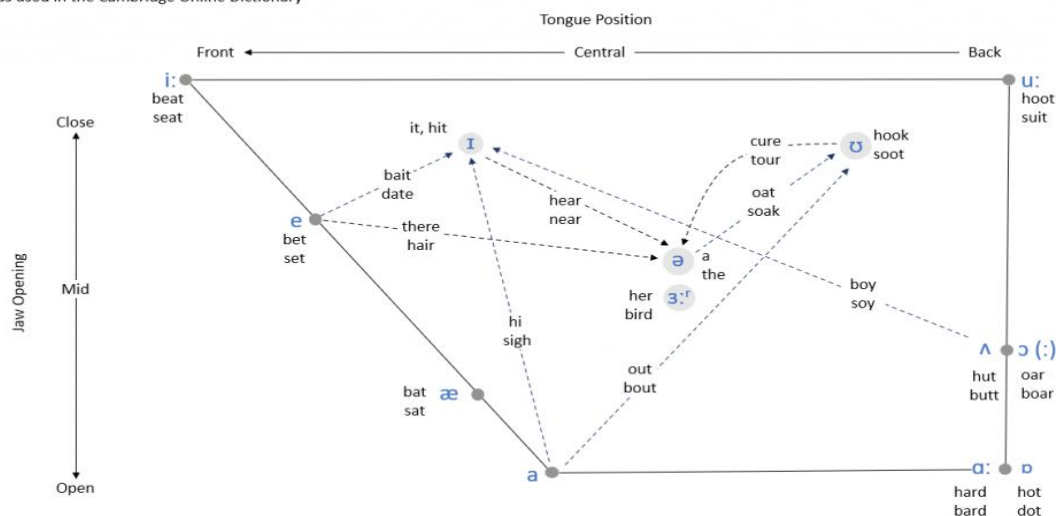
² Most of those are 'minimal pairs': pairs of words whose only difference lies in one sound.

Practicing English Vowels

Because there are many more vowel sounds in English than vowel letters, you again must learn several symbols if you want to be able to read phonetic writing. We produce different vowels by

- Opening our **jaw / mouth** differently (relatively open – relatively close),
- Moving our **tongue** (tip moves towards front or back)
- Varying the **length** of the sound: While some sounds are similar between English and German, their length may differ (DE *Lied* vs. EN *lead* but also *ship* – *sheep*).

IPA Vowels for Received Pronunciation (British English)
as used in the Cambridge Online Dictionary



Task #4: Practice how jaw opening, tongue position and length change one vowel into another. The easiest effect to observe is when you start by moving your tongue backwards from e.g. *seat*. Or try *seat* – *set* – *sit* – *soot* (/sʊt/) – *suit* (/su:t/).

Task #5: With a partner, choose your favorite accent: RP (British 'Received Pronunciation')³ or GA ('General American')⁴. Go to the respective and listen to the audio files provided there. Practice the sounds with a partner. When you are ready, record yourself while pronouncing the words below (again, twice each time):

beat /bi:t/ – bit /bɪt/	bet /bet/ – bat /bæt/
boot /bu:t/ – book /bʊk/	bought /bɔ:t/ – bot /bɒt/
bait /beɪt/	out /aʊt/
boy /bɔɪ/	boat /bəʊt/

³ <https://thinkingasart.philograph.com/received-pronunciation-vowels/>

⁴ <https://americanipachart.com/>

Applying your pronunciation skills

The previous tasks only required one area of knowledge each. For the tasks below you will instead need to use competences gained in different sections of this worksheet.

Task A: Write down what is transcribed below. Can you also find the transcription error?

i: tɪŋ aʊt ɪz wʌn əv laɪfs greɪt pleɪzəz, bət məʊst mi:lz æt
əmeɪɪkn rɛstrɑ:nts ə pækt wɪð prəʊsest fu:d ənd kælərɪz.

Task B: Use the audio file “task B” (Moodle) and the text. Highlight within the text where the speaker made pronunciation errors. Advanced: Write down the phonetic symbol of the sound which should have correctly been used.

This is my first recording of our phonology class.

Task C: Use audio file “task C” and the transcript of *The North Wind and the Sun* below. Highlight any mistakes the speaker makes. Then, describe them in the same way as in task #1.

*The North Wind and the Sun were disputing which was the stronger,
when a traveler came along wrapped in a warm cloak.*

*They agreed that the one who first succeeded in making the traveler
take his cloak off should be considered stronger than the other.*

*Then the North Wind blew as hard as he could, but the more he blew the
more closely did the traveler fold his cloak around him;*

*and at last the North Wind gave up the attempt. Then the Sun shined out
warmly, and immediately the traveler took off his cloak.*

*And so the North Wind was obliged to confess that the Sun was the
stronger of the two.*

Task D: Take turns reading out the *North Wind and the Sun* transcript to a partner, analyze where you made mistakes, and practice the correct pronunciation. Record yourself with the best version you can manage.